



Calling to **ACCOUNT**

As the famed resilience of the Mumbaikar crumbles under the weight of pathetic infrastructure and insecurity following 26/11, politicians have never been so unpopular



PRIYA DUTT, Congress,
Mumbai North Central

Delimitation has added new areas in her constituency. Also her poor performance as MP may spoil her chances this time.

| By Malini Bhupta & Aditi Pai |

Milind Deora is a worried man these days. In his first term as the Member of Parliament representing India's richest constituency, Mumbai South, Deora's constituents have seen the best and the worst. But as elections come, it is the low points that are being remembered. Be it the 2005 floods or the coordinated blasts in local trains a year later, the city's proverbial resilience has been tested consistently. November 26, 2008 proved to

be the last straw. From high-profile investment bankers to families of deceased police officials to ordinary citizens, there is one thing that binds Mumbaikars: anger.

The city's mood has palpably changed and this is reflected most in Mumbai South which will see new contestants like Meera Sanyal, country head of ABN Amro Bank, an independent, and Mona Patel Shah, a doctor belonging to the Professionals Party of India (PPI). From protesting against ageing parliamentarians to dynastic rule in politics, the well-heeled of Mumbai South are clamour-

ing for change. At public meetings, denizens boo when politicians wax eloquent on the nuclear deal and global meltdown. The city's aspiring or sitting MPs don't seem to have answers to basic questions pertaining to the crumbling infrastructure and pathetic state of security.

Despite this wave of discontent, the Congress is repeating four sitting MPs—Deora, Eknath Gaikwad, Gurudas Kamat, Priya Dutt—out of five. Says Pravina Mecklai, a supporter of independent candidate Sanyal: "Deora has done nothing. Infrastructure is in a dismal state. It's